Fire-tech executive convening: Cleveland / NE Ohio, round 1

Prepared 2026-11-07 for Philip Lightmile. Research only. No one was contacted. No emails were drafted or sent.

0. Read this first

Market assumption (please confirm). The brief said "[Cleveland / NYC / West Coast fire tech]". I read that as Cleveland and Northeast Ohio buyers, plus fire and life-safety tech sponsors from anywhere. Reasons:

- The story is Cleveland's.
- Your warm paths are Cleveland's.
- The repo's earlier work is Cleveland-based.

NYC and West Coast sponsors appear where they fit. Pano AI and Seneca are West Coast, and RapidSOS and Mark43 are listed as NYC. I did not build NYC or West Coast buyer lists. If you meant a different market, the sponsor scores carry over but the buyer side must be redone.

Offer used: one 90-minute private screening and conversation, 15 to 25 buyers, one presenting sponsor or up to 3 non-competing co-sponsors, and a one-page readout. Sponsors never get raw responses or attendee lists.

How much to trust the numbers.

- I opened 6 pages in full. Most other citations are search-result summaries that I did not open.
- Pages where fetch was blocked (403) are marked and rest on the search summary.
- Scores are my judgment on thin public evidence. They are for ranking and for deciding where to dig next. They are not measurements.
- "Unknown" is never scored as zero. See the method in section 1.

Source key. Every score cites sources as `[n]` into the index in section F, which has the URL, date and open status.

- **O** = opened and read this session.
- **S** = search summary only, page not opened.
- **F** = fetch blocked, summary only.
- **R** = repo file.

Facts and inference. Text marked **Fact** comes from a cited source. Text marked **Inf** is my inference.

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1. Method and weights

Weights. Default weights are kept: sponsor intent 40%, buyer value 30%, pair fit 20%, access 10%. I made two definitional changes.

1. **Access is not counted twice.** Buyer value uses the first four buyer criteria: purchasing power, active trigger, reference value, likelihood to attend. Accessibility to Philip is scored once, in the 10% access term.
2. **Unknowns are discounted, not zeroed.**
   - Sponsor intent (0 to 100) is the mean of the signals I could evidence, times 20, multiplied by `0.6 + 0.4 × (signals evidenced / 6)`.
   - Buyer value uses the same discount, with 4 criteria in place of 6.

- Every table shows the raw score, the adjusted score and the evidence count. This stops a company with one good press release from outranking one I know more about.

Pair total = 0.4 × sponsor intent (adjusted) + 0.3 × buyer value (adjusted) + 0.2 × pair fit + 0.1 × (access × 20). Pair fit (0 to 100) is my judgment of the value exchange.

Tiers use intent, evidence coverage and whether there is a practical path for a solo founder. A high score alone does not make a tier A.

- **A** = adjusted intent of at least 60, at least 4 signals evidenced, and a plausible local path.
- **B** = real signals, but a large company, a weak local link, or a conflict.
- **C** = poor Cleveland fit or too little evidence.

A. Sponsor table

Signals are 0 to 5 each: **S1** conference or event presence in the last 12 months, **S2** funding or growth in the last 18 months, **S3** customer-reference marketing, **S4** need for local proof, **S5** capacity, **S6** thematic fit with the film. A dash means unknown.

Thematic fit is the film's lens: information not reaching the people who decide, and an inventor's tool that was not trusted until it was needed.

#	Sponsor	Category (HQ)	Intent adj / raw (n of 6)	Signals (S1 S2 S3 S4 S5 S6)	Top 3 signals (fact, then inference)	Tier	Risks
1	**Sonic Fire Tech**	Infrasound fire suppression (Cleveland, per company releases [1] [3])	67 / 67 (6)	2 5 2 4 3 4	**Fact:** $15M seed led by The O.H.I.O. Fund, announced 2026-08-19, after a $3.5M seed in Oct 2025 [3][1]. **Fact:** 2026-05-26 campaign to place 100 backpacks with California departments, taking letters of intent. Earlier demo with Contra Costa Fire [2]. **Inf:** a Cleveland-built, unproven tool needs local proof, and the film's inventor theme fits closely.	**A**	Efficacy claims are company-issued only [2]. A fire-chief room may see a pitch. Framing risk is high (see section E). Competes in category with Seneca and Pano if they are ever added.
2	**Fire-Dex**	Turnout gear and PPE (Medina, OH)	61 / 70 (4)	– 3 – 2 4 5	**Fact:** Medina HQ and more than 500 associates. CEO handoff announced for the start of 2026 [4][F]. Earlier growth claims and a 2023 North Carolina plant [5][6]. **Inf:** Morgan's hood is the ancestor of head-to-toe PPE, so thematic fit is the strongest on the list. A new CEO and local roots suggest a fast decision.	**A**	S1 and S3 unknown. I found no FDIC 2026 listing in one search, which is not proof of absence. PFAS in turnout gear is an industry-wide issue with lawsuits at other cities [36]. I found nothing specific to Fire-Dex, but check before outreach. Competes with MSA (Globe) and Lion.
3	**First Due**	Fire RMS and public-safety software (HQ unknown)	69 / 80 (4)	– 5 3 – 5 3	**Fact:** $355M strategic growth investment, 2025-08, and more than 3,000 agencies [13]. **Fact:** named public buyers include Fresno (cap $354K) and Burlington County, NJ [13]. **Inf:** new capital and big agency counts mean capacity, but I found no Ohio presence.	**A**	S1 and S4 unknown. Direct competitor to ESO. A software vendor in a room of its own prospects needs a no-pitch rule.
4	**MSA Safety**	SCBA, helmets, Globe gear (Pittsburgh)	69 / 80 (4)	5 – – 2 5 4	**Fact:** FDIC 2026 booth 2523 and a 2026-04-21 release on the G1 XR SCBA and FireGrid API [7][O]. The FireGrid release is literally about SCBA data reaching incident commanders. **Inf:** large capacity, but no warm path found.	**B**	Corporate sponsorship is slow for a solo founder. Direct PPE conflict with Fire-Dex. The release names no customers [7].
5	**Axon** (incl. Carbyne)	Body cams, drones, Fusus, 911 (Scottsdale)	78 / 84 (5)	5 5 – 3 5 3	**Fact:** Q1 2026 revenue $807M, up 34% [9]. Axon Week was held 2026-04-07 to 04-10 [9]. Acquired Carbyne for $625M, reported by an aggregator [9]. Fire page lists Air, Fusus and Fleet [9].	**B**	Police-technology baggage. Cleveland's police drone policy is tied up in the DOJ and community police commission process [21]. Conflicts with Motorola and RapidSOS. Its fire push is mostly a marketing page [9].

#	Sponsor	Category (HQ)	Intent adj / raw (n of 6)	Signals (S1 S2 S3 S4 S5 S6)	Top 3 signals (fact, then inference)	Tier	Risks
6	**SkyfireAI**	Drone-as-first-responder program manager	64 / 80 (3)	– – 3 5 – 4	**Fact:** Manages Ohio's statewide DFR pilot for ODOT and DriveOhio. Nine agencies were named 2026-02-10, running about one year [17][O]. **Fact:** Cleveland issued a DFR request for qualifications (2025-06-05, no vendor named) [21][O]. **Inf:** strong local need, but few other signals evidenced.	**B**	HQ, funding and capacity unknown. Drone and surveillance framing. If it bids on Cleveland's RFQ, it must be excluded while the procurement is open.
7	**Rosenbauer America**	Apparatus, electric pumpers	61 / 70 (4)	5 – – 3 4 2	**Fact:** RTX electric pumper at FDIC 2026 [8]. Aurora, OH took a Rosenbauer pumper, from a walk-around video I did not open [8].	**B**	Weak thematic fit (apparatus, not information). Competes with Pierce and Sutphen.
8	**Prepared**	911 and live-video AI (HQ unknown)	56 / 65 (4)	– 4 – 2 4 3	**Fact:** $80M Series C, 2025-05-30, total raised about $135M [15]. **Inf:** Cuyahoga's long-running dispatch consolidation is a possible trigger, but I found no Prepared presence in Ohio [27].	**B**	A 911 vendor sells to dispatch centers, not fire chiefs. Only fits a dispatch-focused room. Competes with Motorola and Axon-Carbyne.
9	**Pano AI**	Wildfire camera and AI detection (West Coast, HQ not confirmed in my sources)	67 / 67 (6)	4 4 4 1 4 3	**Fact:** $44M Series B, June 2025 [10]. **Fact:** named utility customers include PacifiCorp, Xcel and Portland General Electric [10]. A June 2026 EEI expansion release is listed [10].	**C** (Cleveland); would be **A** for a West Coast room	Wildfire is a poor fit for Cleveland buyers.
10	**Seneca**	Autonomous firefighting drones (Sausalito)	56 / 60 (5)	– 5 3 1 3 3	**Fact:** $60M round, Oct 2025 [11]. Cal Fire tested the drones on 2026-07-15. Aspen's fire district bought a five-drone team [11].	**C**	Wildfire and West Coast focus.
11	**ESO**	Fire and EMS records (Austin, not confirmed in my sources)	48 / 55 (4)	– 2 – 2 4 3	**Fact:** NERIS-compatible badge in 2025 and a NERIS rollout release on 2025-11-20 [14]. A Sourcewell cooperative contract runs to 2029 [14]. Its last acquisition I found was in 2024 [14].	**B**	Competes with First Due. The Ohio NERIS status is unclear [39]. I found nothing on 2026 growth.
12	**Motorola Solutions**	Radios, CAD, command center	56 / 65 (4)	– – 3 2 5 3	**Fact:** APX N70 XE fire radio, 2025-04-10 [19]. UK Guardian Hub and Berlin fire body-cam wins reported in March 2026 [19].	**C**	Corporate, with no Ohio fire signal found. Conflicts with Axon.
13	**HEN Technologies**	AI fire-suppression nozzles and software (HQ unknown)	51 / 70 (2)	– 4 – – – 3	**Fact:** $20M Series A and $2M venture debt, Dec 2025 [12].	**C**	Too little evidence.
14	**RapidSOS**	Emergency data platform (NYC, not confirmed in my sources)	51 / 70 (2)	– 4 – – – 3	**Fact:** $100M growth round led by Apax, dated 2025-11-19 by an aggregator [16].	**C**	Aggregator source only. Conflicts with Axon and Motorola.
15	**Mark43**	Police and fire records (NYC, not confirmed in my sources)	44 / 60 (2)	– 4 – – – 2	**Fact:** Blue Owl led a $50M Series G, reported late Oct 2025 [16].	**C**	Mainly a police vendor.

#	Sponsor	Category (HQ)	Intent adj / raw (n of 6)	Signals (S1 S2 S3 S4 S5 S6)	Top 3 signals (fact, then inference)	Tier	Risks
16	**Skydio**	Drones (West Coast, HQ not confirmed in my sources)	43 / 53 (3)	– – 3 2 – 3	**Fact:** Hamilton County, OH Sheriff's goal of 15 Skydio drones, a law-enforcement program [18]. I did not see any Ohio fire customer.	**C**	Law-enforcement framing.

Candidates found but not scored (not enough evidence to score). These are the other 8 names that bring the list to 24.

- **Lion Group.** Turnout gear. Its Ohio HQ is from my own background knowledge, not verified here. [36]
- **ZOLL.** EMS devices and data. I found nothing in the searches that returned.
- **Teledyne FLIR.** Thermal imaging. Not researched.
- **Sutphen.** Apparatus, Dublin, OH. A 2025 strike pushed Columbus to switch a ladder order to Pierce [8]. That is a reputational flag.
- **Pierce / Oshkosh Airport Products.** Apparatus and ARFF. FDIC 2026 showcase noted [8].
- **Frontline Wildfire Defense.** $48M Series A, Oct 2025 [38].
- **XpaceFire Technology.** A May 2026 round from a partly auto-generated Dealroom profile [S].
- **FLAIM Systems.** VR firefighter training. Series A, with date and amount inconsistent across sources [S].

B. Buyer table

Buyer criteria are 0 to 5 each: **B1** purchasing power and fit, **B2** active trigger, **B3** reference value, **B4** likelihood to attend. Value is the adjusted score from section 1. **Access** (0 to 5) is separate and feeds only the 10% term.

The only warm path I could document is the City of Cleveland: the Mayor's support letter and the Office of the Arts review in your own claims file [35]. Everything else is a cold path.

#	Organization	Role targets (role level only, no names)	Value adj / raw (n of 4)	Trigger (fact)	Access (path)	Risks
1	**Cleveland Division of Fire**	Deputy chief of operations; training and health-and-safety officer; EMS liaison. Not procurement staff.	80 / 80 (4)	**Fact:** 778 employees. Public safety is 46% of a $920M general fund, but the city expects "a tight year in 2026" [20][O]. Ordinance 553-2026 buys high-rise kits (May 2026) [22]. DFR request for qualifications, June 2025 [21][O]. Station 36 has had no air conditioning for months (July 2026) [23].	**3.** Mayor's letter and Office of the Arts [35]. See ethics note below.	Public official. Tight budget. Chief's identity unresolved: the city site lists Anthony Luke from 2022, and Wikipedia lists an interim chief with no date [24].
2	**Association of Cleveland Fire Fighters, IAFF Local 93**	Health-and-safety or training committee officers	65 / 65 (4)	**Fact:** Cleveland hosts the 2028 IAFF convention [23]. Station 36 complaint, July 2026 [23].	**2.** Cold.	A union, not a buyer. It is the best validator. Its members are public employees, and it is a party to city labor relations.
3	**Cuyahoga County Office of Emergency Management**	Planner or coordinator for fire and EMS	65 / 65 (4)	**Fact:** coordination slide of 76 police and 52 fire response agencies, May 21, 2026 [26]. Long-running dispatch consolidation and NG911 work, dated background [27].	**2.**	Public. Outcome of any 2026 NG911 contracts unknown.

#	Organization	Role targets (role level only, no names)	Value adj / raw (n of 4)	Trigger (fact)	Access (path)	Risks
4	**Cuyahoga suburban fire departments**: Bedford, Brook Park, Richmond Heights, Warrensville Heights	Fire chief or deputy chief	60 / 60 (4)	**Fact:** all four were named in the State Fire Marshal's equipment grants (a $2M pool across 148 departments), 2026-03-13 [25][O].	**2.**	Public. Small budgets. Strongest peer-level, local attendees. The grant article does not say what the equipment is [25].
5	**Regional dispatch centers**: Southwest Emergency Dispatch, Chagrin Valley, others	Center director or operations manager	60 / 60 (4)	**Fact:** consolidation of 45 PSAPs into regional centers is described as a local decision, from older material [27].	**1.**	Fits only a dispatch-focused room.
6	**Akron Fire Department**	Chief's office; training	60 / 67 (3)	Trigger unknown. I found no 2026 item. New stations are undated [S].	**1.**	Public. Evidence thin.
7	**Austintown Fire Department** (Mahoning County)	Chief	65 / 65 (4)	**Fact:** selected 2026-02-10 for Ohio's statewide DFR pilot [17][O].	**2.**	Roughly an hour from Cleveland. The "Northeast Ohio" tag is my general knowledge.
8	**Cleveland Airport System ARFF** (Hopkins and Burke)	ARFF chief; training officer	55 / 55 (4)	**Fact:** active 2026 solicitations for protective gear and training materials [28].	**1.**	Public. A small unit.
9	**Cleveland EMS and MetroHealth medical direction**	EMS medical director; EMS chief	60 / 67 (3)	Trigger unknown. MetroHealth provides medical direction to Cleveland EMS, which handles over 110,000 calls a year [29].	**2.**	MetroHealth is a county system, so likely public. Treat as public.
10	**Cleveland Clinic EMS**	EMS medical director	72 / 80 (3)	Trigger unknown. Partners with suburban and Akron-area departments on medical direction [29].	**2.**	Private, so no gift limit for its own staff. Its partner departments are public.
11	**Cleveland Water** (Cleveland Public Utilities)	Safety or confined-space program lead	65 / 65 (4)	**Fact:** its treatment plant is named for Morgan, and it held a 2016 centennial ceremony [30]. An Oct 2026 bid listing requires confined-space entry rules, which is a weak trigger [30].	**3.** City entity.	Public. The 1916 tunnel was a city waterworks project, so hosting needs care (see section E).
12	**Ohio Fire Chiefs' Association**	Conference or programs staff	65 / 65 (4)	**Fact:** Officer Development Conference 2027 is July 12 to 15, with a call for speakers [32].	**2.**	A channel partner, not a buyer.
13	**Ohio BWC safety grants**	Not an attendee	55 / 55 (4)	**Fact:** FEEEG gives up to $15K per three-year cycle for turnout gear and related items. BWC reopened more than $41M in FY27 grants [31].	**1.**	A financing route to mention, not a room member. Deadlines conflict across sources [31].

Not scored: industrial and utility safety teams. Cleveland-Cliffs, Lubrizol, and electric utilities such as FirstEnergy. I found no evidence of a fire-technology trigger. FirstEnergy carries the HB 6 settlement flag already logged in `approvals_needed.md` [35].

C. Pair matrix: top 25 pairings

The score is the pair total from section 1. **Value exchange** is "sponsor wants / buyer gets". **Flags:** E = ethics or gift rules, C = competing sponsor, V = villain-framing risk, P = procurement open.

Rank	Score	Sponsor × Buyer	Fit	Value exchange (one line)	Philip's role	Flags
1	72.6	MSA × Cleveland Fire	75	Wants a reference with the region's largest department; Cleveland Fire gets a peer conversation on what SCBA data reaches the incident commander.	Curator and moderator; no demo; readout themes only	E, C (Fire-Dex)
2	71.4	Fire-Dex × Cleveland Fire	85	Wants a local reference for head-to-toe PPE; Cleveland Fire gets a frank talk on what protects firefighters and what never reaches decision makers.	As above	E, C (MSA)
3	70.8	Sonic Fire Tech × Cleveland Fire	70	Wants local credibility for a Cleveland-built tool; the Fire Division gets an early look at an unproven idea and a voice in how it is tested.	As above; screen out claims	E, V
4	70.2	Axon × Cleveland Fire	45	Wants fire-service reach; the Division hears about aerial and video tools. Low fit given police context.	Not recommended	E, V, C
5	69.6	First Due × Cleveland Fire	60	Wants a flagship Ohio reference; the Division discusses incident data and reporting.	Curator	E, C (ESO)
6	69.6	SkyfireAI × Cleveland Fire	70	Wants Cleveland as a DFR customer; the Division sees the Ohio pilot's lessons.	Curator	E, P
7	66.1	SkyfireAI × Austintown	85	Wants a pilot voice; Austintown gets to share its first-year experience with peers.	Moderator	E, P (if Cleveland RFQ open)
8	65.6	First Due × suburban chiefs	80	Wants mid-size adopters; the chiefs get a peer discussion on records and incident reporting.	Curator	E, C
9	64.9	Fire-Dex × Local 93	85	Wants union credibility on PPE; the union gets a platform on gear and exposure.	Curator; keep neutral	V (union and city)
10	64.8	Sonic × suburban chiefs	80	Wants early adopters outside city bureaucracy; the chiefs get a look at a Cleveland-built tool, with no sales ask.	Curator	E, V
11	64.7	Axon × County OEM	50	Wants regional reach; the OEM hears about shared video and drones.	Not recommended	E, C
12	64.4	Rosenbauer × Cleveland Fire	50	Wants an apparatus conversation; the Division weighs electric options under a tight budget.	Curator	E, C
13	63.3	Sonic × County OEM	65	Wants a regional pilot path; the OEM sees an innovation test case.	Curator	E, V
14	63.1	MSA × Local 93	60	Wants SCBA credibility; the union gets input on gear data.	Curator	C
15	62.6	MSA × suburban chiefs	65	Wants mid-size reach; the chiefs compare notes on SCBA and data.	Curator	E, C
16	62.4	Fire-Dex × suburban chiefs	80	Wants local reference accounts; the chiefs discuss gear funded by BWC and state grants.	Curator	E
17	62.3	Sonic × Cleveland Water	50	Wants a utility voice on tunnel and confined-space hazards; Cleveland Water gets the Morgan story told in context.	Moderator	E, V
18	61.9	Fire-Dex × Ohio Fire Chiefs' Association	70	Wants a conference link; the association gets a case story for 2027.	Partner	none
19	61.6	MSA × Akron Fire	70	Wants a regional reference; Akron gets a peer exchange.	Curator	E, C
20	61.6	First Due × Akron Fire	70	Wants Ohio adopters; Akron discusses data and reporting.	Curator	E, C
21	61.3	Sonic × Austintown	55	Wants a pilot-minded buyer; Austintown shares what it learned about trialing new tools.	Moderator	E
22	60.4	Fire-Dex × Akron Fire	80	Wants a second city reference; Akron weighs gear choices.	Curator	E
23	60.1	SkyfireAI × County OEM	55	Wants countywide interest; the OEM hears about DFR coordination.	Curator	E, P
24	59.9	Prepared × County OEM	70	Wants a regional dispatch reference; the OEM discusses consolidation.	Curator	E, C

Rank	Score	Sponsor × Buyer	Fit	Value exchange (one line)	Philip's role	Flags
25	58.4	Prepared × dispatch centers	80	Wants dispatch buyers; the centers get a peer talk on call data.	Curator	E, C

What the matrix does not show. Rank is arithmetic. My recommendation in section D departs from it on purpose: MSA and Axon rank higher than Fire-Dex and Sonic, but they carry competition, framing and access problems that the score does not capture.

D. Recommended first room and 10 outreach actions

First room

Sponsors (2, with one held back):

1. **Fire-Dex (presenting).** Reasons: local HQ, family-owned (faster decision), strongest thematic fit, and 4 of 6 signals evidenced. This is a judgment call, not a score output. MSA is the alternate presenting name, but do not seat both.
2. **Sonic Fire Tech (co-sponsor).** Reasons: Cleveland-built, a fresh $15M seed that signals capacity, and a stated need for local proof. It does not compete with Fire-Dex. It needs the guardrails below because of its framing risk.
3. **Held back: First Due.** Add as a third sponsor only if you want a data-and-reporting thread. Do not contact ESO if you do.

Buyers (16 seats, one optional):

Organization	Seats	Why
Cleveland Division of Fire	3	Largest department and reference name. Ops, training/safety and EMS liaison. Not procurement staff.
IAFF Local 93	2	Validator; Station 36; 2028 convention.
Cuyahoga suburban departments (Bedford, Brook Park, Richmond Heights, Warrensville Heights)	4	Peer-level, local, grant recipients.
Akron Fire	2	Second city reference.
County Office of Emergency Management	1	Regional view.
Cleveland Clinic EMS	1	Private reference, no gift limit.
MetroHealth / Cleveland EMS	1	Medical direction.
Cleveland Water	1	Morgan's story and confined-space safety.
Cleveland Airport System ARFF	1	Different environment, same hazards.
Austintown Fire (optional)	1	Ohio DFR pilot voice, if travel works.

Guardrails.

- About 14 of 17 seats are public employees. Treat the Ohio Ethics rules as the design constraint.
- Sponsors present for the opening only and leave before the conversation.

- No meals or gifts to public attendees beyond what Ethics Commission advice clears.
- No sponsor holds an open bid with an attending agency.
- Sponsorship is disclosed in every invitation.
- The Mayor's letter supports filming *Standing in Fire* [35]. Do not use it as an endorsement of this convening or of any sponsor.

The 10 outreach actions, in order

1. **Ethics first.** Ask the Ohio Ethics Commission for advice on the exact event design before inviting any public employee. Give it the sponsor-paid screening, the no-meals rule and the limited sponsor presence. Context: R.C. 102.03(E) and (F) [33]. This is not legal advice. Get counsel.
2. **Settle the open facts.** Confirm who leads Cleveland Fire [24]. Confirm with the Mayor's office how the support letter may be mentioned [35].
3. **Anchor validators, no ask.** Contact IAFF Local 93 and the Ohio Fire Chiefs' Association. Ask for advice and whether a listening role would be useful. This tests demand before any sponsor money.
4. **Fire-Dex.** Approach the CEO's office and the marketing or events lead, from public professional pages. Warm path unknown.
5. **Sonic Fire Tech.** Approach the founder or the partnerships lead. Condition: no efficacy claims and no demo in the room.
6. **Hold First Due.** Decide on a data thread. Contact only one of First Due or ESO.
7. **Suburban chiefs.** Approach Bedford, Brook Park, Richmond Heights and Warrensville Heights at role level, through the County OEM advisory channel if possible. I found no Cuyahoga fire chiefs' association page.
8. **Cleveland Fire.** Invite at role level through the Chief's office, free of charge, with sponsors named.
9. **Remaining buyers.** Cleveland Clinic EMS, MetroHealth, Cleveland Water, Cleveland Airport System, and Akron.
10. **Close sponsors, then set the date.** Send a one-page term sheet: no lists, aggregate readout only, editorial independence, conflict disclosures. Then lock the date. Fill any open seats from Akron and Austintown.

E. Conflicts and framing risks

Competing sponsors in one room (pick one per row).

- PPE: Fire-Dex vs MSA (Globe, Cairns) vs Lion.
- Records: First Due vs ESO.
- 911 and video: Axon (owns Carbyne) vs Motorola vs RapidSOS vs Prepared.
- New suppression and detection: Sonic vs Seneca vs Pano vs HEN.
- Apparatus: Rosenbauer vs Pierce vs Sutphen.

Buyers who are sponsors' competitors. None found among the scored buyers. Check each attendee's in-house build or open-bid status before invitations go out.

Public-sector ethics.

- About 14 of 17 recommended seats are public employees.
- The Ohio Ethics Commission has no fixed dollar threshold for a substantial gift, and vendor-paid meals, travel and lodging are covered by Advisory Opinion 89-014, which I did not open [33].
- Cleveland Division of Fire, suburban departments, Akron, Cleveland Water, the Airport System and the County are the highest-exposure attendees. MetroHealth is probably public as well.
- Cleveland Clinic EMS is the clean private seat.

Framing risks: pairings that cast buyers as villains.

- **Sonic with any public buyer (highest risk).** The film's arc is an inventor whose tool was not trusted until it was needed. Sonic is the inventor in the room, and fire chiefs become the gatekeepers who "didn't listen". Mitigation: frame buyers as people who carry the risk and decide what reaches the fireground, with no demo and no ask.
- **Cleveland Water as host or buyer.** The 1916 tunnel was a city waterworks project. Some accounts say the city refused to back Morgan's Carnegie nomination [34]. The Carnegie Hero Fund says it decided on risk, not race, and found no evidence that race was the reason [34][O]. Keep the film's claims inside that record.
- **Axon and SkyfireAI with Cleveland.** Police drones sit in an unresolved policy process [21]. A DFR pitch can read as surveillance.
- **Local 93 and the city in one room.** The union and the city are in labor relations. Keep the topic safety, not pay or staffing.

F. What I could not verify, and the source index

Could not verify

- **The market.** My Cleveland assumption is unconfirmed. NYC and West Coast buyer lists were not built.
- **Who leads Cleveland Fire.** Sources conflict [24].
- **Conference presence.** Only MSA is opened [7]. Rosenbauer, Axon and Pano are search summaries. The FDIC exhibitor list and the Ohio Fire Chiefs' vendor list were not obtained.
- **Headcount and event-marketing hiring.** I did not check any job boards. Every S5 (capacity) score rests on size and funding, not hiring.
- **Named customer quotes.** I opened none. S3 scores rest on named customers in press and public procurement records.
- **Primary releases that returned 403.** Sonic's May 2026 release and the Citybiz piece on its August 2026 round, plus the Fire-Dex 2025 release. Those facts rest on search summaries, several of which agree.
- **Fire-Dex specifics.** I found no 2026 news, and the CEO handoff is a May 2025 announcement I could not open.
- **Cleveland's DFR request for qualifications.** I found no outcome or vendor.
- **Ordinance 553-2026, the County OEM May 2026 slide, and the airport solicitations.** All from search summaries.
- **Ohio's NERIS status.** One vendor note says Ohio stays on NFIRS unless state guidance changes, undated [39].
- **HQs** for First Due, Prepared, HEN, RapidSOS, Mark43 and Lion.
- **Whether any sponsor has a warm path to any buyer.** I found none.
- **Ethics advice.** The Commission summaries are not advisory opinions, and I did not open AO 89-014. This is not legal advice.
- **Individuals.** I deliberately named none. Role-level only.

Source index

#	Source	URL	Date	Status
1	Sonic Fire Tech $3.5M seed	https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20251016885417/en/Sonic-Fire-Tech-Raises-%243.5M-to-Launch-the-Worlds-First-Infrasound-Fire-Defense-Solutions-for-Homeowners-Enterprises-First-Responders-and-Public-Utilities	2025-10-16	S
2	Sonic California backpack campaign	https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260526618682/en/California-Fire-Agencies-to-Evaluate-New-Acoustic-Fire-Suppression-Backpack-Technology	2026-05-26	F (403)
3	Sonic $15M seed, O.H.I.O. Fund	https://secure.businesswire.com/news/home/20260819177149/en/The-O.H.I.O.-Fund-Announces-Lead-Investment-in-Sonic-Fire-Techs-Seed-Round-Khosla-Ventures-Reinvests-Capping-Cleveland-Startups-Seed-Funding-at-%2415M and https://citybiz.co/article/891728/sonic-fire-tech-closes-15m-seed-financing-led-by-o-h-i-o-fund	2026-08-19	S, F (403)

#	Source	URL	Date	Status
4	Fire-Dex leadership and size	https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20250515002455/en	2025-05-15	F (403)
5	Fire-Dex North Carolina expansion	https://www.crainscleveland.com/manufacturing/fire-dex-medina-expanding-north-carolina-operation/	2023-07	S
6	Fire-Dex growth release	https://www.fireapparatusmagazine.com/?p=124701	2023-01	S
7	MSA at FDIC 2026	https://news.msasafety.com/2026-04-21-FDIC-2026-MSA-Safety-Advances-Firefighter-Protection-for-a-More-Complex-Fireground	2026-04-21	O
8	Rosenbauer at FDIC 2026; Sutphen strike	https://www.rosenbauer.com/en-us/news/news-hub/specialist-press/2026/04/rosenbauer-america-at-fdic-2026 ; https://www.firehouse.com/apparatus/type/aerial/news/55305344/strike-at-sutphen-forces-columbus-oh-to-switch-to-pierce	2026-04; 2025-07	S
9	Axon Q1 2026; Axon Week; Carbyne	https://www.barchart.com/story/news/1750851/axon-reports-q1-2026-revenue-of-807-million-up-34-year-over-year ; https://www.govevents.com/event/15051/axon-week-2026 ; https://multiples.vc/private-comps/carbyne	2026-05-06; 2026-04; 2025-11	S
10	Pano AI Series B and customers	https://builtin.com/articles/pano-raises-44m-series-b-20250623 ; https://www.renewableenergyworld.com/power-grid/smart-grids/15-utilities-are-already-using-an-ai-powered-wildfire-detection-startup-that-just-raised-another-44m/	2025-06	S
11	Seneca $60M; Cal Fire test	https://aviationweek.com/aerospace/advanced-air-mobility/autonomous-firefighting-drone-developer-seneca-raises-60m ; https://dronexl.co/2026/07/22/cal-fire-tests-seneca-autonomous-drones/	2025-10; 2026-07-22	S
12	HEN Technologies Series A	https://www.firehouse.com/technology/artificial-intelligence/news/55339235/hen-technologies-to-build-operating-system-for-fire-defense	2025-12	S
13	First Due $355M; Fresno agenda	https://inforcapital.com/news/first-due-raises-355m-to-scale-ai-powered-public-safety-platform/ ; https://agendas.fresno.gov/en/legislation/id-24-1572-18859	2025-08	S
14	ESO NERIS; Sourcewell	https://business.mammothtimes.com/mammothtimes/article/gnwcq-2025-11-20-eso-launches-neris-solution-with-end-to-end-workflow-integration-for-fire-service ; https://www.sourcewell-mn.gov/cooperative-purchasing/030425-ESO	2025-11-20	S
15	Prepared $80M Series C	https://siliconangle.com/2025/05/30/prepared-raises-80m-expand-ai-powered-emergency-response-platform/	2025-05-30	S
16	RapidSOS $100M; Mark43 Series G	https://www.pulse.bot/venture-capital/news/rapidsos-secures-100m-d4058a47-487b-48fe-ac68-71723b659f84/ ; https://app.mergerlinks.com/transactions/2025-10-30-mark43-inc	2025-10 and 11	S (aggregators)
17	Ohio statewide DFR pilot; SkyfireAI	https://spectrumnews1.com/oh/columbus/news/2026/02/10/ohio-drone-first-responder-pilot-program ; https://www.suasnews.com/2025/10/driven-by-legislative-vision-ohios-statewide-drone-first-responder-program-takes-flight-under-skyfireai-management	2026-02-10; 2025-10	O; S
18	Hamilton County Skydio program	https://www.yahoo.com/news/drones-first-responders-program-launched-183154980.html	2025	S
19	Motorola fire radio and 2026 wins	https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20250410537547/en/Motorola-Solutions-APX-N70-XE-Radio-Combines-Mission-Critical-Voice-Communications-with-Smart-Applications-for-Fire-Crews-in-Harsh-Conditions	2025-04-10	S
20	Cleveland 2026 budget	https://signalcleveland.org/cleveland-city-budget-2026-first-look-mayor-justin-bibb-city-council/	2026-02-02	O
21	Cleveland drone-as-first-responder RFQ	https://spectrumnews1.com/oh/columbus/news/2025/06/05/cleveland-drones-first-responders	2025-06-05	O

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22	Council fire equipment, Ord. 553-2026	https://cpo.soar.com/articles/7977200/Cleveland/Cuyahoga-County/Ohio/Council-approves-firefighter-equipment-purchase-and-accepts-Ohio-drug-enforcement-grant	2026-05-14	S
23	Local 93 Station 36; 2028 convention	https://www.cleveland19.com/2026/07/21/cleveland-firefighters-union-says-station-36-has-been-without-air-conditioning-months/ ; https://www.firehouse.com/careers-education/press-release/55139022/international-association-of-fire-fighters-iaff-cleveland-secures-2028-international-association-of-fire-fighters-convention	2026-07-21	S
24	Cleveland fire chief (conflicting)	https://www.clevelandohio.gov/news/mayor-bibb-swears-anthony-p-luke-new-cleveland-fire-chief ; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cleveland_Division_of_Fire	2022-11; undated	S
25	State Fire Marshal grants, Cuyahoga	https://wtam.iheart.com/content/2026-03-13-cuyahoga-county-fire-depts-receiving-grant-funding/	2026-03-13	O
26	Cuyahoga OEM	https://www.cuyahogacounty.gov/ready?ccpage=1	2026-05-21 slide	S
27	Cuyahoga dispatch consolidation (background)	https://signalcleveland.org/cuyahoga-county-gets-federal-funding-for-upgrades-to-911-system/ ; https://www.strongsville.org/departments/communications/southwest-emergency-dispatch-center-1/southwest-emergency-dispatch-center	2019 and later	S
28	Cleveland Hopkins solicitations	https://starbridge.ai/buyer/cleveland-hopkins-international-airport-0	2026	S
29	MetroHealth and Cleveland Clinic EMS	https://www.metrohealth.org/en/medical-services/emergency-medical-services/medical-direction-partners/ ; https://my.clevelandclinic.org/departments/ems	undated	S
30	Cleveland Water; confined-space bid	https://clevelandwater.com/node/144 ; https://bidbanana.thebidlab.com/bid/VUxLXs2SstByNXkRMi0f	2016 ceremony; 2026-10	S
31	Ohio BWC safety grants	https://www.ohiotownships.org/news/bwc-reopens-safety-grants-program ; https://www.workcompcentral.com/news/article/id/b15d77aefe44de61fa612613568c2ee43e765be8	2026-08	S
32	Ohio Fire Chiefs' 2027 conference	https://ohiofirechiefs.com/aws/OFCA/pt/sp/conference	2026	S
33	Ohio Ethics Commission	https://ethics.ohio.gov/ethicslaw/factsheets/ThePrivateSector.pdf ; https://ethics.ohio.gov/training/ondemand/ecourses/OELFF2/transcript.html	undated	S
34	Carnegie Hero Fund on Morgan	https://www.carnegiehero.org/behind-the-scenes-shedding-light-on-the-complicated-case-of-black-inventor-garrett-morgan/	2021-02-03	O
35	Repo: Mayor's letter, FirstEnergy flag	`cleveland-film/CLAIMS.md` (letter dated 2026-10-07); `approvals_needed.md`	2026-10	R
36	PFAS in turnout gear (industry context)	https://agendas.fresno.gov/es/legislation/id-26-629-21333 ; https://www.lionprotects.com/blog/turnout-gear-materials-technology	2024 to 2026	S
37	Waterworks tunnel disasters (history)	https://case.edu/ech/articles/w/waterworks-tunnel-disasters	undated	S
38	Frontline Wildfire Defense Series A	https://www.axios.com/pro/climate-deals/2025/10/28/frontline-wildfire-defense-funding-norwest	2025-10-28	S

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39	NERIS and Ohio (vendor guide)	https://support.firstduesizeup.com/hc/en-us/articles/44011886112795-Step-by-Step-Guide-for-Transitioning-Existing-Customers-from-NFIRS-to-NERIS	undated	S